A PARENT'S GUIDE TO SUPPORTIVE COMMUNICATION

How to talk so your child feels heard

Why communication matters

Children and adolescents are more likely to share concerns when they feel listened to and respected. Supportive communication does not mean agreeing with everything a child says; it means trying to understand their experience before responding.

Helpful alternatives

Instead of saying	Try saying
“You're overreacting.”	“I can see this is important to you. Tell me more.”
“Because I said so.”	“Let me explain why this limit matters.”
“You never listen.”	“Let's find a way to understand each other.”
“There's nothing to worry about.”	“What is worrying you most right now?”
“Just tell me what's wrong.”	“I'm here when you're ready to talk.”

Five habits that strengthen communication

1. Listen without interrupting.
2. Ask open-ended questions.
3. Acknowledge feelings before offering advice.
4. Set boundaries calmly and consistently.
5. Choose a suitable time to discuss difficult issues.

A practical exercise

During your next conversation with your child, try listening without immediately correcting, questioning, or solving the problem. Then ask: “Have I understood what you mean?”

Remember: Strong relationships are built through repeated moments of respect, understanding, and trust—not through one perfect conversation.

For educational purposes. This guide provides general information and does not replace individualized professional advice.